Both the DAs, Gp Capt Sucharu Rai and Col GS Grewal, SC, respectively, were professionals of the highest order. In fact, Col GS Grewal did a fantastic job in the evacuation of Indian nationals from Sudan in April 2023 as part of Op Kaveri, with his statement, 'Trust me, all of you will reach home safely' going viral.[3] The strategic signalling was not lost on Pakistan. During this visit, particularly to Saudi Arabia, Veena's presence opened doors that would otherwise have been shut. She was the only one who could interact with the ladies of the host country and the insights she gained helped us understand these countries much better. Most of the ladies she met told her how they were not in favour of polygamy and how demeaning it is to their self-respect. She was also able to visit the Princess Nourah Bint Abdulrahman University (PNU), a public women's university located in Riyadh, the capital of Saudi Arabia, which is the largest women's university in the world. The setting up of the PNU was a step towards modernity and showed the world the importance given towards female education. It gave us an idea of how Saudi Arabia is not as fundamentalist as it is made out to be. Such insights would have been lost had Veena not accompanied me.

During the visit to Israel, we went to the Har Addis View Point overlooking Lebanon and were also shown one of the tunnels, five to six feet wide and more than 80 feet underground, with its own lighting and ventilation system, used by the Lebanese Hezbollah to infiltrate Israel. In each of the visits, we tried to go beyond the purely official and do something different. We were told in our childhood that several Jews from Pune and its surrounding areas, Bene Israelis as they were known, had emigrated to Israel in the 1960s and 1970s. We asked the DA, Gp Capt K Sundarmani, if he could locate some of them, which he did. During the visit, we had high

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